complicated things further. Khan did not always get along well with Nuristani, and neither with his successor Daud Saba. But more than Saba and Nuristani, it was Maulvi Khodaidad, a powerful cleric of the Herati *ulema* who had Karzai's support from Kabul, who opposed Khan. Khodaidad had his own favoured strongmen, who took on Mullah Mustafa's men on the ground, and helped keeping Khan politically marginal in Herat.

Open to the continuation of the NATO forces in Afghanistan for years to come, Khodaidad criticised Khan for making Herat unstable. 'During the Jihad he [Ismael Khan] fought against Russia. Because of that people respected him. But after that, when he was governor of Herat, all things were destroyed, and he started bothering people' complains Khodaidad.[135] The rivalry is ongoing and tested India's diplomatic skills to a considerable extent. Mandated to ensure the timely and peaceful construction of the dam and other Indian aid projects in West Afghanistan, managing these local rivalries was part of the consul-general's job (in addition to keeping an eye on the Pakistani consulate nearby). And the success of it was visible in India's close relationship with both Khodaidad and Khan. Offering regular visas to Khodaidad for annual medical trips to New Delhi was part of this diplomacy that convinced the cleric that India could genuinely bring peace to Afghanistan as both the government and the insurgents liked Indians.[136]

But at the same time, threats against Indians working at the dam site, and to the dam itself, despite India's skillful diplomacy, were real (in 2009 a senior WAPCOS official was nearly kidnapped on the road to Salma Dam).[137] In light of these politics, the charge against Mustafa of trying to destroy the dam in 2012 had to be taken seriously. In order to settle the situation, Mukhopadhaya visited the project site with Ludin in November 2012. Instead of halting work on the dam, India disbursed more funds for its timely completion. When asked if he was concerned about Iranian meddling in the project by a local Afghan journalist, Mukhopadhaya diplomatically replied that there was more than one reason for the delay in the completion of the project, not all of which were security related. Throwing the mantle on the Afghan government he added that 'the issue of security must be managed by the Afghan government because we cannot control it'.[138] In March 2013, Afghan security forces captured about 1,300 kg of high-